

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 32 Summary

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The present progressive is one of the easiest topics for English speakers to learn in Spanish because it closely mirrors how we talk in English. It's used to describe actions happening **right now**, like "I'm eating" or "She's reading." In Spanish, this is formed using the verb **estar** + a **gerund** (called *el gerundio* in Spanish).

How to Form the Present Progressive

To form the present progressive in Spanish:

Conjugate the verb *estar* in the present tense:

yo estoy
tú estás
él/ella/usted está
nosotros estamos
vosotros estáis (Spain)
ellos/ustedes están

Then add the gerund (present participle):

- For **-ar verbs**, drop **-ar** and add **-ando**
hablar → hablando (speaking)
- For **-er** and **-ir** verbs, drop the ending and add **-iendo**
comer → comiendo (eating)
vivir → viviendo (living)

Examples:

Estoy hablando. — I am speaking.

María está comiendo. — María is eating.

Estamos viviendo en México. — We are living in Mexico.

Common Irregular Gerunds

Some gerunds are irregular or have spelling changes to preserve pronunciation.

Stem-changing -ir verbs:

decir → diciendo — saying
pedir → pidiendo — asking for
seguir → siguiendo — following
dormir → durmiendo — sleeping
morir → muriendo — dying

Verbs with a vowel before -er/-ir endings (for smoother pronunciation):

leer → leyendo — reading
oír → oyendo — hearing
construir → construyendo — building
destruir → destruyendo — destroying
incluir → incluyendo — including

Examples:

Ella está leyendo una novela. — She is reading a novel.

Estamos oyendo un ruido. — We're hearing a noise.

Están construyendo una casa. — They are building a house.

Using the Present Progressive for Practice

Try using this formula to practice with everyday vocabulary:

Estar (conjugated) + gerund

Estoy buscando las llaves. — I'm looking for the keys.

Estamos comiendo tacos. — We're eating tacos.

María está durmiendo. — María is sleeping.

Juan está tratando de aprender español. — Juan is trying to learn Spanish.

When you want to say someone is *trying to do something*, you can use:

estar + tratando de + infinitive

Important Notes on Usage

Spanish speakers don't use the present progressive as often as English speakers do.

Often, Spanish uses **simple present tense** where English would use the progressive:
¿Qué haces? — What are you doing? (literally: What do you do?)
¿Qué buscas? — What are you looking for?

These are *present tense* but understood as present progressive in context.

You will almost never use the present progressive with **verbs of motion** like **ir (to go)** or **venir (to come)**:

Estoy yendo a la tienda ❌

Voy a la tienda ✅ — I'm going to the store

Just use the simple present:

Mi amigo viene. — My friend is coming.

Practice Tips

Practice talking to yourself throughout the day using:

¿Qué estás haciendo? — What are you doing?

Answer with:

Estoy buscando información. — I'm looking for information.

Estoy leyendo sobre vacaciones. — I'm reading about vacations.

Estoy tratando de aprender español. — I'm trying to learn Spanish.

You can even mix in other constructions you've already learned to build fluency.

Final Thoughts

The present progressive in Spanish is easy to form and familiar to English speakers, but be careful not to overuse it. In many situations, native Spanish speakers will default to the simple present. Keep an eye out for those patterns and adjust with practice.